

Case Study: Aurelia Motion Systems – Organizational Stability and Change

Opening

On a rainy Monday in March 2026, Elena Vogt, CEO of Aurelia Motion Systems, received two messages about the same AI system. The first came from the COO and was optimistic: “NOVA has finally made our sales routines faster.” The second came from the Head of New Mobility Sales and was more troubling: “The system may be teaching us to recognize the past more efficiently than the future.”

Aurelia Motion Systems was a German automotive supplier with around 1,500 employees. The company produced precision components for thermal management systems, sensor housings, and lightweight assemblies for European carmakers and tier one suppliers. By 2026, Aurelia had to adapt to unstable electric vehicle programs, shrinking combustion related product lines, and strong efficiency pressure from customers. The leadership board introduced NOVA, an AI supported sales suite, to help the organization respond faster and make better use of its data.

After six months, the board saw a paradox. Sales routines had changed visibly. Meetings were shorter. Forecasts arrived earlier. Proposal drafts moved faster. Yet several managers worried that NOVA was also making old assumptions more durable. Familiar customers remained highly visible. Unfamiliar opportunities remained difficult to evaluate. Historical categories appeared in dashboards as if they were neutral facts.

Elena asked the external consulting team to prepare a recommendation. “I need to know whether NOVA helps us adapt, or whether it makes our existing sales logic more efficient. Faster routines are not enough if they make us faster at doing the wrong things.”

A short guide to terms used in this case

Term	Plain meaning for this case
NOVA	The name of Aurelia’s AI supported sales suite. It combines forecasting, opportunity scoring, and proposal drafting.
NOVA Forecast	A tool that compares customer schedules, order histories, CRM entries, and market signals to highlight likely changes in demand.
NOVA Signal	A tool that produces customer and opportunity scores. Sales managers use these scores to prioritize requests.
NOVA Quote	A tool that drafts proposal documents by drawing on previous proposals, engineering documents, customer messages, price lists, and margin rules.
Series Sales	The sales team responsible for established products and recurring business with major customers.
New Mobility Sales	The sales team responsible for newer electric vehicle, battery, and sensor related opportunities. Requests are often less standardized.
Sales Operations	The team that maintains CRM data, prepares sales reports, monitors sales process quality, and supports pricing analysis.

Sales routines before NOVA

Before NOVA, Aurelia’s sales routines were slow and uneven. Weekly meetings reviewed long account lists. Forecast meetings often included stories about customers, informal warnings, and discussions of whether a schedule change reflected real demand or customer bargaining. Proposal routines in New Mobility Sales required repeated conversations between sales, engineering, production planning, and finance.

The process frustrated the CFO because it consumed time. But it also created occasions for questioning assumptions. Account managers sometimes challenged historical customer priorities. Engineers sometimes warned that a promising project was less attractive than it looked. Production planners sometimes asked whether a forecast reflected market change or only a temporary customer adjustment.

NOVA was expected to professionalize these routines. The business case promised faster meetings, better forecast discipline, earlier identification of margin risk, and more consistent prioritization. It was not introduced as a strategy tool. But once managers began using its scores and alerts, NOVA started to shape what the organization noticed first.

Routines after NOVA

In Series Sales, weekly sales meetings changed quickly. Instead of reviewing every major account, managers began with the NOVA priority queue. The meeting chair projected the top alerts, asked account managers for explanations, and moved quickly through items with low scores. Several participants welcomed the new rhythm.

Markus Rehm, Head of Sales, said: “Before NOVA, we spent ninety minutes finding the problem. Now we start with the problem. That is exactly the kind of discipline we need.”

Others saw a loss. Martin Gruber, Head of Production Planning, said: “Before, account managers told stories, sometimes too many stories. Now they sometimes bring a score. The score is useful, but a score is not a reason.”

In New Mobility Sales, NOVA Quote changed proposal routines. Managers could ask NOVA to draft a proposal, generate alternative price ranges, and identify similar past projects. This helped when requests were close to known components. It was less helpful when customers described early electric vehicle projects with incomplete specifications.

Exhibit 1. Selected indicators reviewed by the leadership board

Indicator	Baseline, March to August 2025	Series Sales after rollout	New Mobility pilot after rollout
Average length of weekly sales meeting	92 minutes	48 minutes	64 minutes
Share of meeting agenda based on NOVA generated alerts	Not applicable	73 percent	41 percent
Forecast accuracy for the next eight weeks	61 percent	77 percent	65 percent
Number of customer opportunities discussed outside the NOVA top queue per month	31	14	19
Average time from customer request to first written response	5.8 working days	2.6 working days	3.2 working days
Proposal drafts returned by engineering for major revision	18 percent	20 percent	37 percent
Documented overrides of NOVA opportunity scores per month	Not recorded	64	18

How old assumptions entered the system

NOVA learned from historic CRM data, past accepted and rejected quotes, customer payment records, strategic customer flags, margin histories, and previous management classifications. These inputs were not wrong. They represented Aurelia’s organizational memory. The difficulty was that this memory had been built during a period in which combustion related products, established OEM relationships, and long-term volume agreements shaped the company’s success.

A Sales Operations analyst described the concern: “The system is very good at telling us which customers used to matter. I am less sure it is good at telling us which customers might matter next.”

One example concerned HansaDrive, a long-standing customer with declining combustion related volumes. NOVA Signal continued to rate HansaDrive highly because of its payment history, historical revenue, and strategic customer flag. A second example concerned Voltrix Battery Systems, a smaller new mobility customer with incomplete payment history and uncertain volume projections. NOVA rated the opportunity as low priority. Two New Mobility managers disagreed because they believed the project could become strategically important if Aurelia entered the battery cooling segment early.

The disagreement was not easy to resolve. HansaDrive still generated revenue. Voltrix was uncertain. Several managers said they found it harder to argue for low scored opportunities after NOVA became the meeting agenda.

Exhibit 2. Extracts from internal shadowing notes

Situation	Observation extract
Series Sales meeting, Monday 8:30 a.m.	The meeting begins with the NOVA priority queue. Three alerts concern established customers. A low scored request from a smaller sensor customer is skipped because it is not in the top list. One account manager later says the request may deserve attention because the customer recently hired a former OEM purchasing director.
Forecast review, Tuesday 2:00 p.m.	Production Planning asks why NOVA expects higher demand from HansaDrive. The account manager says the system found schedule changes and historic ordering patterns. Planning asks whether this reflects actual end customer demand. The answer remains unclear.
New Mobility proposal review, Wednesday 11:15 a.m.	NOVA Quote suggests using a previous cooling module template for a battery housing request. Engineering warns that the similarity is superficial because tooling and liability assumptions differ. The draft is revised substantially.
Sales Operations dashboard review, Friday 9:20 a.m.	Several opportunity scores rely on strategic customer flags entered before the EV transition accelerated. Sales Operations notes that no routine exists for systematically reviewing these flags.
Leadership board preparation, Friday 4:10 p.m.	The COO praises faster meetings. The Head of New Mobility asks whether the company is under discussing unfamiliar opportunities because they require longer explanation and often appear outside the NOVA queue.

When faster routines became harder to question

NOVA changed the rhythm of management attention. Items with high scores appeared first. Items with low scores required someone to spend political capital to bring them back into the discussion. Managers could override the AI, but overrides had to be documented. Some saw this as useful discipline. Others said it discouraged experimentation.

A New Mobility manager said: “If I want to pursue a low scored opportunity, I have to explain why I am ignoring the system. If I follow a high scored legacy opportunity, I do not have to explain as much. That changes what feels normal.”

The AI program lead resisted the criticism. “NOVA does not forbid anything. Managers can override it. The problem is not the tool but whether managers use their judgment.” Yet Elena was not convinced that formal override rights were enough. She asked whether routines that began with NOVA outputs made some forms of judgment more likely and others less likely.

The CFO emphasized the cost pressure. He argued that Aurelia needed speed and consistency now, not another layer of debate. “If every score becomes a philosophical discussion, we are back to the old process,” he said. The Head of New Mobility replied: “If no score becomes a discussion, we may miss the market shift we claim to be responding to.”

The board discussion

At the March board meeting, the leadership team considered several options. One option was to scale NOVA quickly because the routines had become visibly more efficient. Another was to restrict NOVA to standardized Series Sales work. A third option was to continue the New Mobility pilot while improving the data model. A fourth option was to redesign management routines so that NOVA outputs became prompts for discussion rather than the structure of discussion itself.

The disagreement was not about whether NOVA had value. Most board members agreed that it had improved short term forecasting and reduced response time. The disagreement concerned adaptation. Did NOVA help Aurelia see changing market conditions earlier, or did it mainly make historically successful patterns easier to reproduce?

Elena turned to the consulting team. “I do not want a generic warning that history can be biased. I need an operating concept for using NOVA in a changing market. Which routines should remain fast, and where do we need deliberate interruption?”

Your consulting task

You are consultants advising Elena Vogt and the leadership board of Aurelia Motion Systems. Your group focuses on how NOVA shapes organizational stability and change. Your task is not to judge whether AI is generally useful. Your task is to recommend how Aurelia should use NOVA so that it supports adaptation rather than merely accelerating existing routines. Prepare a board pitch. Your pitch should use evidence from the case and end with a concrete concept that the board could adopt. In particular, Elena Vogt is interested in the following questions:

1. What is the central stability and change problem created by NOVA? Use evidence from the case.
2. What should Aurelia do next: scale NOVA broadly, restrict it to selected work, continue the pilot, or redesign management routines before scaling? Justify your choice and discuss the main trade off.
3. Develop an Adaptive AI Use Concept with up to five rules. Specify how Aurelia should use NOVA outputs, review old assumptions, surface anomalies, and protect attention for unfamiliar opportunities.

Disclaimer

This teaching case is fictional and intended solely for classroom use. Generative AI has been used to develop this case.